

MEETING OUR ANCESTORS

REBUILDING FOSSILS

Studying the fossil remains of early humans and their relatives can allow us to find out more about our ancestors and how they lived. By using new techniques, such as scanning, 3D printing, and DNA analysis, scientists can recreate what our ancient relatives might have looked like by making detailed models. These then help them understand how different human species evolved over millions of years.

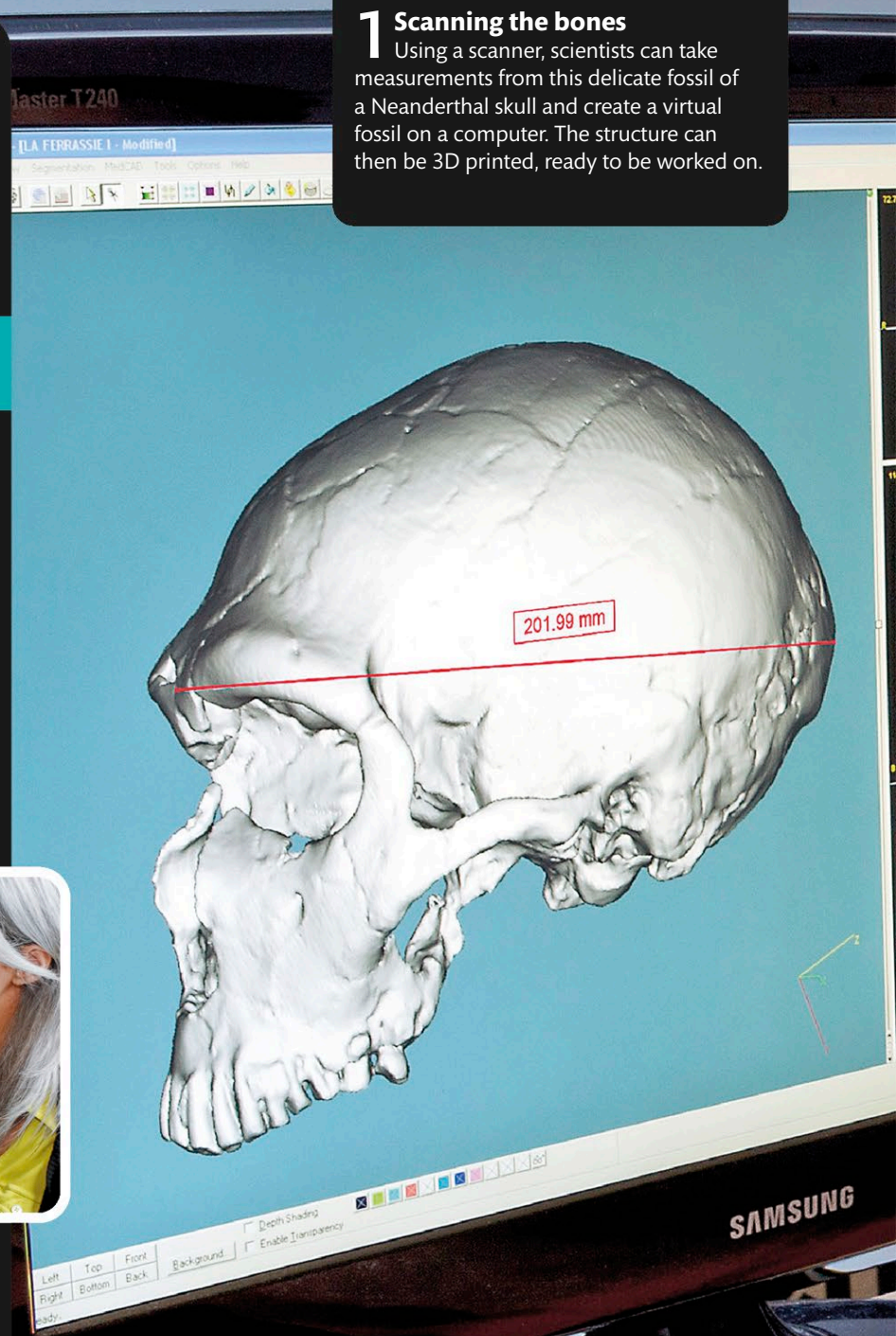
ART AND SCIENCE

Bringing fossils to life is called paleoart, as it combines the science of paleobiology with art. Here, French paleoartist Élisabeth Daynès works on a reconstruction of extinct human relative *Australopithecus africanus*.



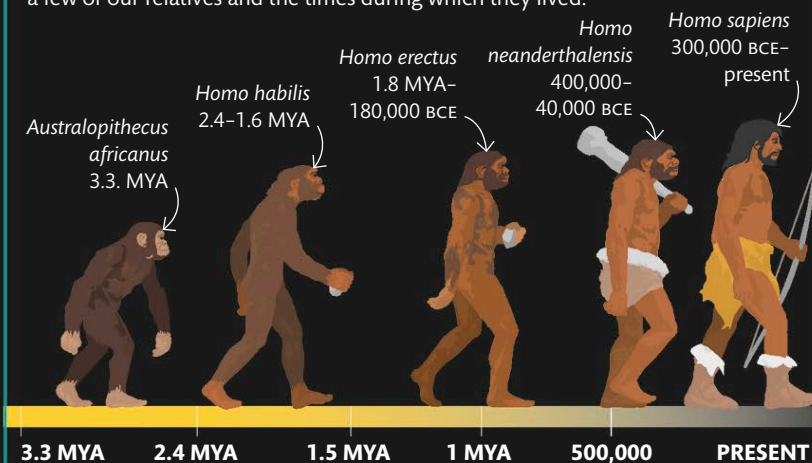
1 Scanning the bones

Using a scanner, scientists can take measurements from this delicate fossil of a Neanderthal skull and create a virtual fossil on a computer. The structure can then be 3D printed, ready to be worked on.



HUMAN EVOLUTION

Evolution is the process of how living things change over long periods of time. When lots of small changes make a type of organism very different, it becomes a new species. The first human species evolved from ancient apes 3.3 millions of years ago (MYA). Our species, *Homo sapiens*, did not evolve until around 300,000 years ago, but it is the only one to survive to the present day. The diagram below shows a few of our relatives and the times during which they lived.



More than
6,000 fossils
of early humans
have been
discovered
so far.